Public Comment on Draft Policies *-Permission to Post (Redacted by permission)*

Please provide your comments on policies currently proposed for revisions or rescissions, or new policies. Policies are open for public comment for a minimum of 21 days between the First Reading and the Second Reading, when a adopt the policy.

Policy you are providing comment on *

New: Student Use of Personal Electronic Devices in Schools x.xx.xxx-P

Do you provide permission to post your comments on the PPS website? *

- ( ) Yes, with name
- (•) Yes, without name
- ( ) No. Share only with Board and District staff

Name *

[redacted]

Email *

[redacted]

Your School Community *

McDaniel Highschool

Please provide your comments below *

I do not want my kids' phones taken away or locked up during the day. I am against any policy that doesn't allow them access to their phones at certain times during the day. While I agree that there should be some school policy, it should be up to each individual teacher how their classroom is run. Phones are not going away. The amount of money required for Yondr pouches alone should be a big NO especially considering the budget cuts that are coming this year. Policing these policies will also create a huge headache and will be borderline totalitarian. Body and bag searches for a phone? Detention for carrying a phone on their person? Where does it end? From what I have seen and heard, teachers and students are getting better at self managing phone usage, especially from 3 years ago after Covid. Total bans and bag searches are NOT the answer.

This form was created inside of Portland Public Schools.

Google Forms

Comment on a Policy in the Public Comment Period - December 8-10, 2024

Timestamp	permission to post comments	Name	Email	School Community	Please provide your comments below
12/8/2024 12:28:05	Yes, with name	Ryan Curren	[redacted]	Winterhaven School	I'm writing in support of the Board's resolution "Student Use of Personal Electronic Devices in Schools". However, please consider amending the resolution to 1) encourage schools to use the Yondr pouches and 2) signal the District's intent to seek funding to support principals to purchase the Yondr pouches. The policy needs an institutional enforcement plan rather than putting the burden on individual teachers to enforce it. Making teachers constantly have to be the bad guy erodes the relationship with the students and adds stress to the teacher's life which ultimately degrades the educational environment.
12/9/2024 10:21:14	Yes, with name	JT Homberg	[redacted]	Benson	I think banning cell phone throughout the day is the way to go. It will help the students greatly and also help protect students who are victims of bullying. Not having cell phones during a 30 min lunch avoids all kind of logistical nightmares and make enforcement of the plan easier. As long as the schools have a way to enforce it, I think it is a good policy and the benefits will be apparent quickly.
12/9/2024 17:45:46	Yes, with name	Andrew Waxman	[redacted]	Ida B Wells	Schools need to take into account the fact that there are students who are legal adults as well as students who are old enough to enlist in the US military. Restricting high schoolers from using their devices during lunch in the hopes the new social relationships will bloom is sheer fantasy. There have always been students who sit by themselves or have their head in a book/magazine/graphic novel. I would argue that if the students aren't allowed to use their devices during lunch for whatever reason, then the teachers should not be allowed to use their phones either. As for compliance devices such as yonder pouches and school wide searches, schools need stop wasting time and money. Every act of noncompliance by students simply delegitimizes the school administration's authority and credibility in the eyes of students and public. Phone caddies or off and away in the classroom is enough.
12/10/2024 8:27:06	Yes, with name	Sam Waxman	[redacted]	Ida B. Wells HS	Before I begin, I will state that I agree with the expectation that students keep their phones away during class time, and the following comments are just regarding lunch time for high schoolers. The new proposed phone policy does not benefit students or teachers, rather it is the equivalent of painting over rust and declaring the rust gone. As an 18 year old student, I could legally drop out and join the US Army, but if I decide to use my phone at lunch, I will now face strict disciplinary consequences? It seems like PPS is more focused on saying they have an answer than actually solving problems. In an article by Willamette Week, students at Grant High School estimated that phone policy compliance was only around 50%. In a district already as stretched thin as PPS is, spending $60,000 on an initiative is just poor management. Additionally, PPS is ignoring the obvious social root of its problems. There have always been students that choose not to pass time with other students, with or without phones in schools. If the negative student response is a sign that "we're all addicted to our phones", PPS should put their money where their mouth is and make teachers and administrators put their phones away too.

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12/9/2024 11:26:09	Yes, without name	[redacted]	[redacted]	Benson Cluster.	SO...we are trying the "Honor" system this year and doing our best to enforce the no cell phones in class policy. It has been moderately successful however, it is still a lot of work and behavioral management put back on the teachers. As a result it is hard to be consistent and manage that constant current of behaviors with the children. The issue here is that if we do not have near total buy-in with the staff, parents and kids, then it falls apart. It is also draining and causes staff burnout, conflicts and interruptions, even in the best of circumstances and consistency. One other issue is safety and group gatherings due to the children's unique ability to instantly communicate and "meet up" in the halls and nooks and crannies of the school building when they should be in class and safe. Lastly, although the cell phone can be a great tool, it does take away from social interaction and learning about peer interactions. We have a whole generation of kids that "Check out" too much and are in essence "Addicted" to the instant and omnipresence of the internet. These are my observations from 2007 until now, I hope my wisdom helps us all make the right decisions.

Timestamp	permission to post comments	Name	Email	School Community	Please provide your comments below
12/9/2024 14:04:13	Yes, without name	Damien Miles-Paulson	dmilespaulson@pps.net	Benson	Hello, my name is Damien Miles-Paulson. I've been an educator in the PPS community since 2018, first as a teaching artist with Writers in the Schools and now as a teacher at Benson High School. I've taught at almost every high school in Portland: Benson, Lincoln, Ida B. Wells, McDaniel, Franklin, Grant, Roosevelt, and Cleveland. When I first started, phones were rarely a problem in classes, either because they were less common or because students understood that they needed to be away during class time. Back then, students being distracted on their computers was more of an issue. When we came back to in-person instruction in 2021, the classroom looked, and continues to look, very different. At first, students disappearing into phones was the rule rather than the exception. Looking out at my first class after the pandemic, a classroom of checked out, tired, and socially isolated students who struggled to maintain focus for more than a few moments, was a dystopian experience, one that almost caused me to quit teaching. All the teachers and adults I talked to seemed to struggle with what to do, many of them wondered if anything could be done, or if doing something, if taking the phones away was tantamount to a violence against these pandemic kids. Rather than quit, I stuck through it, and while things improved, the phones remained a constant issue. Many things were tried or not tried. Parents, teachers, and students all admitted there was a problem but all the solutions seemed to lead to the same outcome: constant distraction, an inability to focus that can seem almost painful to students, kids skipping or taking long bathroom breaks to use their phones in the halls during class-all the greatest hits. When phones, and even computers, so I'll just say "screens" are present in a class, students and teachers suffer. In the last year, as schools have cracked down, I've seen improvement, but the only learning environments that I've been in where the problem seems to have been solved are places like Grant, and to a lesser degree, Lincoln, where strict policy has been put in place, one that has largely fallen to admin to enforce so that teachers can focus on building healthy, engaged classes. I think PPS should implement a no phones policy similar to the one at Grant. In my conversations with teachers at Grant I have heard about what a transformational thing it has been for both teachers and students to be free of cell phones. Yes, of course, there are ways to get around the policy, to find cracks, but it seems that overall, the introduction of a no cell phone policy has filled the halls and classrooms with the right kind of vitality and a kind of social and intellectual connection that can only be had when we engage with other humans directly, free of our screens. If such a policy was implemented where I teach at Benson, it would immediately benefit my students and me as a teacher. There would be a messy, fitful transition, no doubt, but those difficulties would be worth it.

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Timestamp	Do you provide permission to post your comments on the PPS website?	Name	Your School Community	Please provide your comments below
12/13/24 9:43 am	Yes, with name	Kerry Zambrano	Benson Tech	I support the Cell Phone Policy as written in the Wang Amendment, specifically no cell phone use all day long, including lunch. Cell phone availability during school hours, whether that is passing time and/or lunch, makes enforcing the policy during class time difficult. Students have access to their phones in their pockets or backpacks, and this makes them more easily accessible, and does not promote the 'off and away for the day' attitude. Teachers, like myself, spend excessive time focused on enforcing this INSTEAD of teaching. Students are losing instructional time and focus because of the difficulty of enforcement and the proximity of their phones. Studies have shown that 'off and away for the day' is the model that brings about increased focus and test scores. Parents have other ways to contact their students, specifically through the main office and email. Parents can also track their student using phone location apps, if they are concerned about their student's location. I would welcome any parent to call and confirm that their student is in class or not.

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12/15/2024	Yes, with name	Luke Hotchkiss		Benson Polytechnic HS & Peninsula Elementary	I understand that the intended unstated enforcement mechanism of the cell phone policy is to be lock boxes in each classroom. When three board members visited my shop at Benson and viewed my cell phone lockbox that I have mounted on the wall, I specifically said that I do not recommend this as the enforcement mechanism district wide. Let me elaborate as to why. If this is the common experience that students have everywhere they will defeat this system either by taking each others phones or by lying about how someone took their phone, in order to get the school district to purchase them a new phone. I don't think this is the road you want to go down, because the expense and the drama of that will far exceed that of the Yondr pouches quickly. The wall mounted boxes can work in limited situations such as mine, but it is not a systemwide solution. They are easily broken into, the first student that I had to put their phone in the lock box pried the box open to extract his phone. It takes a specific kind of teacher and classroom culture for it to work, it is not something that can be mandated and succeed.

Hi, this is Andy Tu. And this is my written public comment for the phone policy. A lot of what I've written here on this google doc was already said by me at the last public comment regarding the phones, back in December 2nd. So I've just highlighted which paragraphs, or parts of each paragraph that are new and additional supporting details and emphasis. I hope you enjoy what's written here. And have a great night.

Phone Restrictions

The new phone restrictions with the magnetic-lock pouches for inside the school buildings, and / or the off and away plan that includes lunch have been very shocking to many students. Not only is this a poorly conceived plan, It could also be very dangerous. In case of an emergency, or post, we would need to contact families to let them know whether or not we are okay. Parents could be worried about their inability to contact their child to check and make sure they're okay. And If they're not, they should be. We should also be able to contact emergency services in case classroom phones or other phones in the buildings are out of service. Having these have made students feel unsafe.

We are not the only school district that believes in this. The Boulder Valley High School District from Denver Colorado, are having the same upcoming phone policies to their schools as well. And according to FOX31, a news station from all the way in Denver Colorado, students there, in that district are having opinions THE SAME AS OURS about it!!, also saying that we should have our phones to contact for emergencies. Phones again are more likely able for us to literally just call for help at those times, instead of giving ourselves away to criminals, somehow. And since parents are the ones that are most wanting us to care about school and do well, they would already know not to call their child in the middle of the school day. And if that's the case, all students should already be expecting little to no unexpected calls and interruptions. Are phones should mostly be quiet during the school day anyway.

We would still need our devices for educational purposes, like researching and scanning QR codes. There's also students that want to listen to music to help them focus. Some students really need that, especially if they have ADHD like my friend [redacted]. (Again, the same person

that supported me in a rant video). We can't ignore students who need those types of accomidations. **If you're going to ask next "We'll why can't we just use the school chromebooks? Like, that's a piece of technology we can use. Right?" Well many students are having problems with the barrier known as SafeSearch. That system limits things we can do on them, as well as blocks multiple other educational sites, which makes it a huge flaw BEYOND just blocking students from needing to listen to specific types of music.**

For some reason, most of the parents are agreeing to this. The administrators will just side with the parents, which is biased. Students and other schools, like Grant and Benson, are also saying yes with the phone ban. But me and my friends at McDaniel are the school that sees the bigger picture. Yes, I saw the video on the KATU2 NEWS YouTube channel. And I hope you saw it as well. I'm also not afraid to call out Portland Oregon's other news station "Fox 12 Oregon / Good Day Oregon," who with such a large number of viewers at home, should not make their opinion sound like a popular opinion, or an exact fact.

I'm aware that there has been a problem with some students being too distracted on their phones during instructional time, and also the fact that students look like they're less connected with their peers and teachers when there's not. Me, and a couple other people have some understanding that the district wants us to focus on school more. However, it actually still doesn't forbid students from still being able to have it during lunch and / or break, especially break inside the classroom. Students already, or should be connecting during class and group discussions, and of course group projects. Implementing a phone ban district wide is very excessive, and punishes all students, for just that small fraction of all PPS students that are irresponsible with the phones that deserved to get penalized. In McDaniel, most students are responsible enough to put their phones in their own bags. However, if there are some students who are both creative and rebellious enough, one of the workarounds they could think of is bringing a fake phone into the pouches.

In my opinion, It still should be clear that we should still be sticking to the old fashioned. The teachers can put the phones of the irresponsible students in a box that is not too secure so that we can still take them out quickly during an urgent situation, instead of even thinking of spending part of the school budget on these magnetic pouches. Students who refuse to comply,

just get penalized, and meets with the dean and / or principles. **I get that those bags are still unlockable. But the technology like that can malfunction. So then what happens?**

Also, blaming the phones for cyberbullying, as well as threat messages, is also low. We should talk to children about when and how to use the phones, as well as the media we consume from it. Just because we are restricting phone activity of phones inside the school buildings, doesn't mean it prevents the same drama you believe (which is that it's just caused only by phones and that it's the only source to blame by the way) is going to happen, when students are outside of the school campus. And of course, once school's out, it's clear that it's out of PPS jurisdiction. So the school wouldn't be saving anyone anyway. THAT'S how you accept reality, not blaming the existence of the phones. I've been in a social skills class for the past 3 years back in McDaniel. And I'm still in that class this year as well, so that makes all my years of high school. While my teachers there are also saying yes with the phone policy, I've still started most of that class with a conversation about issues with PPS, and also trying to convince them that managing the phone usage should be a social skills lesson instead.

You just said we are facing budget cuts. And yet, the pouches are what we are going to do with the budget we do have. Yeah, part of the $40 million budget is spent on thousands of those pouches. The money was not used wisely, because it seems PPS is more interested in spending it on surveilling the students, instead of what it should go to, Such as going back to better teaching tools and equipment, ways to improve the classroom environment, and bringing back teachers and non-teaching that have been affected by the budget cuts.

I was the public comment on the 12th of December, 2024, speaking out exactly everything I've said here about the phones. Days later, the board then made some announcements. The first is that the all-day phone ban will not include lunch, which then switches to having the ban during lunch after all, with no exceptions. Students are wondering, and asking how and why with the sudden change. Additionally, it seems like the board members are the only ones that get a vote on whether the decision is finalized or not, which proves my point that all the student feedback means nothing to them. Yep, instead of us getting a say, we are just out of the way. All of this obviously had made the situation worse than it's ever been. It will restrict, again the parent-student communication, and just makes communication between students much more difficult.

And like I said again, putting more time-bans on the cell phones continues to make students feel more and more unsafe. I just want to ask what's really the point and benefit of this, and the sudden change of mind, as well as why do they think their perspectives are the only ones that matter.